

SILENT

1. Passage anchor

> “I was always afraid of saying the wrong thing, so I often ****stayed silent**** even when I had an idea.”

Passage meaning

****silent**** = not speaking; saying nothing

****沉默的；不說話的****

Here, the speaker had ideas but deliberately did not express them because of shyness and fear of making a mistake.

****stay silent**** = continue not to speak

****保持沉默；不出聲****

Practice

1. She ****stayed silent**** because she was afraid of giving the wrong answer.

她因為怕答錯，所以一直****保持沉默****。

2. He had an opinion, but he chose to ****remain silent**** during the discussion.

他其實有自己的看法，但在討論中選擇****保持沉默****。

Core meanings of SILENT

2. silent — not speaking

= not saying anything

****沉默的；不說話的****

Examples

1. Everyone became ****silent**** when the teacher entered the room.

老師走進教室時，大家都****安靜下來，不再說話****。

2. He sat ****silent**** throughout the meeting.

他整場會議都****一言不發****。

This is the core human-behavior meaning.

3. stay / remain silent

= continue without speaking

保持沉默；繼續不說話

Examples

1. She decided to **remain silent**.
她決定**保持沉默**。
2. He **stayed silent** when they asked for his opinion.
他們問他的意見時，他一直**沒有說話**。

Both are very common:

* **stay silent** — neutral and natural

* **remain silent** — slightly more formal

4. fall silent

= stop speaking and become silent

突然沉默下來；停止說話

Examples

1. The room **fell silent** when the announcement began.
公告開始時，整個房間**突然安靜下來**。
2. She **fell silent** when his name was mentioned.
一提到他的名字，她便**沉默了下來**。

The important idea is a **change from speaking/noise to silence**.

5. go silent

= suddenly stop speaking or communicating

突然沉默；不再說話

Examples

1. He suddenly **went silent** during the conversation.

他在談話途中突然**沉默了**。

2. She **went silent** after hearing the news.

她聽到消息後便**不再說話**。

Compared with **fall silent**, **go silent** is somewhat more conversational and can also describe devices or communication channels.

Absence of sound

6. silent — making no sound

= completely or nearly without sound

無聲的；沒有聲音的

Examples

1. The room was completely **silent**.

房間裡完全**沒有聲音**。

2. The streets were strangely **silent** at night.

夜晚的街道異常**寂靜**。

Here, **silent** describes the absence of audible sound, not specifically a person refusing to speak.

7. silent movement / footsteps

= producing little or no sound

無聲的；悄無聲息的

Examples

1. The cat moved with **silent steps**.

那隻貓**悄無聲息地**移動。

2. She made a **silent entrance** into the room.

她**悄無聲息地**走進房間。

8. silent machine / device / operation

= operating with little or no audible noise

****靜音的；低噪音的；無聲運作的****

Examples

1. The new fan is almost completely ****silent****.

這台新風扇運作時幾乎完全****沒有聲音****。

2. The motor runs ****silent**** at low speed.

這部馬達在低速運轉時幾乎****無聲****。

For products, ****quiet**** is often more natural when some sound remains.

Communication without words

9. silent — expressed without speech

= communicated through actions, expressions, gestures, or looks rather than words

****無言的；不透過言語表達的****

Examples

1. They exchanged a ****silent glance****.

他們彼此交換了一個****無言的眼神****。

2. She gave him a ****silent warning**** with her eyes.

她用眼神給了他一個****無聲的警告****。

The communication still exists; only spoken words are absent.

10. silent agreement / approval / consent

= agreement or approval shown without being stated explicitly

****默認；無言的同意****

Examples

1. His lack of objection was taken as ****silent agreement****.

他沒有反對，被視為****默認****。

2. Everyone seemed to give their ****silent approval****.

大家似乎都以不出聲的方式表示了**默許**。

This can imply that behavior or non-objection communicates acceptance.

11. silent understanding

= understanding shared without needing to be spoken

無言的默契；心照不宣的理解

Examples

1. There was a **silent understanding** between them.

他們之間有一種**無言的默契**。

2. The two friends reached a **silent understanding** and changed the subject.

兩位朋友形成了**心照不宣的默契**，於是換了話題。

Refusing or failing to communicate

12. silent — not giving information or comment

= refusing or choosing not to speak publicly about something

保持沉默的；不作回應的

Examples

1. The company has remained **silent on the issue**.

公司對這個問題一直**保持沉默**。

2. Officials were **silent about the reason** for the change.

官員對改變的原因**沒有作出說明**。

Common patterns:

* silent on an issue

* silent about something

* remain silent on something

13. keep silent about something

= deliberately not tell other people about something

對.....守口如瓶；不透露.....

Examples

1. He promised to **keep silent about the plan**.

他答應對這項計畫**保密不說**。

2. She **kept silent about what she had seen**.

她對自己看到的事情**保持沉默**。

This can overlap with **keep something secret**, but emphasizes not speaking.

Lack of activity or response

14. phone / radio / communication goes silent

= stop producing messages, signals, or communication

失去聯絡；沒有回應；停止傳訊

Examples

1. His phone suddenly **went silent**.

他的手機突然**沒了動靜**。

2. The radio station **fell silent** shortly after midnight.

那家電台在午夜過後不久便**停止廣播**。

This is a metaphorical extension of “no sound.”

15. someone goes silent online

= stop posting, replying, or communicating for a period

停止回應；突然不再聯絡

Examples

1. She **went silent** on social media for several weeks.

她有好幾週在社群媒體上**完全沒有動靜**。

2. After our last conversation, he suddenly **went silent**.

上次談話之後，他突然**不再回應**。

The meaning is broader than literal absence of sound.

Letters and pronunciation

16. silent letter

= a written letter that is not pronounced

****不發音的字母；不發音字母****

Examples

1. The ****k**** in **knife** is a ****silent letter****.

knife 裡的 ****k**** 是****不發音字母****。

2. English contains many words with ****silent letters****.

英語中有很多含有****不發音字母****的單字。

This is a distinct linguistic use.

17. silent sound / silent consonant

More precisely, a ****silent consonant/letter**** is written but not pronounced.

Examples:

* ****b**** in **thumb**

* ****w**** in **write**

* ****l**** in **calm**

For learners, ****silent letter**** is the most useful term.

Film and performance

18. silent film / silent movie

= a film from the era before synchronized spoken dialogue became standard

****默片；無聲電影****

Examples

1. Charlie Chaplin became famous during the **silent-film era**.

卓別林在**默片時代**成名。

2. We watched an old **silent movie** in class.

我們在課堂上看了一部老**默片**。

A silent film was not necessarily literally soundless when shown; live music was often used. The term refers chiefly to the absence of synchronized spoken dialogue.

Computing and technology

19. silent mode

= a device setting that prevents ordinary notification sounds

靜音模式

Examples

1. Put your phone on **silent mode** during the meeting.

開會時請把手機調成**靜音模式**。

2. My phone was on **silent**, so I missed your call.

我的手機調成了**靜音**，所以沒接到你的電話。

Very common modern use.

20. silent notification / alert

= notification delivered without an audible sound

靜音通知；無聲提醒

Examples

1. The app sends **silent notifications** in the background.

這個應用程式會在背景傳送**靜音通知**。

2. I received a **silent alert** on my watch.

我的手錶收到了一個**無聲提醒**。

21. silent installation / silent update

In computing, **silent** can mean operating without requiring visible user interaction or prompts.

無需使用者操作的；靜默執行的

Examples

1. The software supports **silent installation**.
這套軟體支援**靜默安裝**。
2. The update was installed **silently** in the background.
更新已在背景中**自動執行**，沒有跳出操作提示。

This is a useful specialist extension, but lower priority for general learners.

Figurative inactivity

22. silent partner

= a business investor who contributes money but does not take an active role in management
隱名合夥人；不參與日常經營的合夥人

Examples

1. He joined the business as a **silent partner**.
他以**不參與日常經營的合夥人**身分加入這家公司。
2. The restaurant was partly funded by a **silent partner**.
這家餐廳有部分資金來自一名**不參與經營的投資合夥人**。

This is an established business expression.

23. silent majority

= a large group of people whose views are not publicly expressed
沉默的大多數

Examples

1. The campaign claimed to represent the **silent majority**.
該活動聲稱代表**沉默的大多數**。

2. It is difficult to know what the ****silent majority**** actually thinks.

很難知道那些****沒有公開表態的大多數人****真正怎麼想。

This phrase can appear in social and political discussion; its exact referent depends on context.

Related forms

24. silence — noun: absence of sound

= a state in which little or no sound can be heard

****寂靜；安靜；無聲****

Examples

1. The room fell into ****silence****.

房間陷入了****寂靜****。

2. We sat together in complete ****silence****.

我們一起坐著，一片****安靜無聲****。

25. silence — noun: absence of speech or response

= failure or choice not to speak, answer, or communicate

****沉默；不回應****

Examples

1. Her ****silence**** made everyone uncomfortable.

她的****沉默****讓大家感到不自在。

2. After several days of ****silence****, he finally replied.

****沉默了好幾天****之後，他終於回覆了。

26. silence — verb: make someone or something stop speaking or producing sound

= cause to become silent

****使安靜；使停止發聲****

Examples

1. The teacher raised her hand to ****silence the class****.

老師舉手示意，讓全班****安靜下來****。

2. He pressed a button to ****silence the alarm****.

他按下一個按鈕，把警報器****關成無聲****。

27. silence — verb: prevent someone from expressing views

= stop or suppress someone from speaking publicly

****使噤聲；壓制發言****

Examples

1. Threats were used to ****silence critics****.

有人用威脅手段讓批評者****噤聲****。

2. She refused to be ****silenced****.

她拒絕被人****壓制而不能發聲****。

This is more forceful than merely asking someone to be quiet.

28. silently

= without speaking or making sound

****默默地；無聲地；靜靜地****

Examples

1. She ****silently**** walked out of the room.

她****默默地****走出房間。

2. He nodded ****silently****.

他****一言不發地****點了點頭。

Context decides whether the emphasis is:

* no speech

* no sound

* no visible objection

High-value expressions

29. the silent treatment

= deliberately refusing to speak to someone to show anger or displeasure

****冷戰；故意不理人****

Examples

1. She gave him ****the silent treatment**** all evening.
她整個晚上都對他****不理不睬****。
2. The ****silent treatment**** rarely solves an argument.
****冷戰不理人****通常無法真正解決爭執。

Highly idiomatic.

30. suffer in silence

= experience pain, difficulty, or unhappiness without telling others

****默默承受；有苦不說****

Examples

1. You don't need to ****suffer in silence****.
你不必一個人****默默承受****。
2. For years, he ****suffered in silence****.
多年來，他一直****默默承受痛苦****。

31. silent as the grave

= completely silent

****寂靜無聲；死一般安靜****

Examples

1. The building was ****silent as the grave****.
那棟建築裡****死一般寂靜****。
2. After the announcement, the room was ****as silent as the grave****.

公告之後，房間裡**鴉雀無聲**。

Strong and somewhat literary.

32. a moment of silence

= a short period during which people remain silent, usually to show respect for someone who has died or for a tragic event

默哀；默哀片刻

Examples

1. The ceremony began with **a moment of silence**.

儀式以**默哀一分鐘 / 片刻默哀**開始。

2. Everyone observed **a moment of silence** for the victims.

大家為受害者**默哀片刻**。

Key contrasts

33. silent vs quiet

These frequently overlap, but they are not identical.

silent

= making or involving **no sound**, especially no speech

無聲的；沉默的

quiet

= making relatively little sound; calm and not noisy

安靜的；聲音小的

Compare:

> He was **silent**.

> 他**一句話也沒說**。

> He was **quiet**.

> 他很**安靜 / 話不多**。

A quiet person can still speak.

A silent person, in the relevant moment, does not speak.

34. silent vs mute

****silent****

= not currently speaking or making sound

****沉默的；無聲的****

****mute****

can mean unable or unwilling to speak, or having sound turned off in technology

****不能說話的 / 靜音的****

Compare:

* remain ****silent**** during the meeting

* ****mute**** the microphone

For devices, ****mute**** is often an action; ****silent**** often describes the resulting mode or condition.

35. silent vs speechless

****silent****

= saying nothing, whether by choice or circumstance

****沉默的****

****speechless****

= temporarily unable to speak, usually because of shock, anger, surprise, or emotion

****驚訝 / 震驚得說不出話****

Compare

> She remained ****silent**** because she was shy.

> 她因害羞而****保持沉默****。

> She was ****speechless**** when she heard the news.

> 她聽到消息時****震驚得說不出話****。

36. silent vs still

****silent****

= without sound

****無聲的****

****still****

= without movement

****不動的****

Something can be:

* silent but moving

* still but noisy

* both silent and still

Example:

> The child sat ****still and silent****.

> 那個孩子坐著****一動不動，也一聲不出****。

Meaning map

The core idea of ****silent**** is:

****absence of audible expression****

From this develop several branches:

****person not speaking****

→ stay silent

→ ****保持沉默****

****place/object producing no sound****

→ silent room / silent machine

→ ****寂靜的 / 無聲的****

****communication without words****

→ silent glance / silent agreement

→ ****無言的 / 默認的****

****lack of public comment****

→ remain silent on an issue

→ ****不表態****

****lack of communication****

→ phone/radio goes silent

→ **沒有動靜 / 失去聯絡**

technical absence of sound or interaction

→ silent mode / silent installation

→ **靜音 / 靜默執行**

written but unpronounced language

→ silent letter

→ **不發音字母**

So although the Traditional Chinese translation changes, the central semantic thread remains
something that is not audibly expressed.

Passage recap

> “I often **stayed silent** even when I had an idea.”

Here:

silent = **not speaking**

The speaker was not literally unable to speak. The surrounding context shows that fear and shyness made the speaker choose not to contribute.

Best Traditional Chinese renderings:

* **保持沉默**

* **不出聲**

* **不敢開口**

* contextually: **即使有想法也不敢發言**

MCQ-ready meaning

silent in **“stayed silent”**

= **not speaking / saying nothing**

沉默的 ; 不說話的

The key distinction is:

* **silent** → no speech / no sound

* **quiet** → little sound / calm

* **speechless** → temporarily unable to speak because of strong emotion